

MIDDLE ADULTHOOD

40-60 YEARS APPROX



1

WHAT DOES IT MEAN TO BE IN MIDDLE ADULTHOOD (40-60 YRS)



<https://www.mentimeter.com/join/presentation/688617acac1b674d7ba09beebda6d8d4c4f6411e672efed4p>

2

MIDDLE AGE IS

- Loosing touch with technology
- Finding you have no idea what young people are talking about
- Preferring a night in rather than night on the town
- You don't know any top 10 songs
- Choosing clothes and shoes for comfort rather than fashion
- Booking a cruise
- Socks for Christmas and happy about it
- Obsessive recycling and knowing dates
- Always carrying tissues!

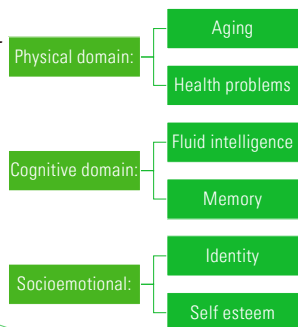
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WHAT DOES IT MEAN TO BE MIDDLE AGED?

- Established
- More opportunities
- Many demands
- Facing mortality
- Changes
- Relationships

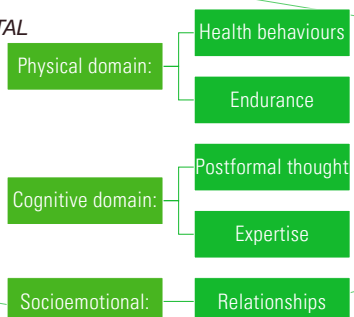
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DEVELOPMENTAL LOSSES



5

DEVELOPMENTAL GAINS



6

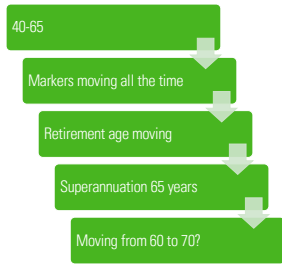
CHALLENGERS IN MIDDLE ADULTHOOD

- Identity crisis
- Biological clock
- Longer life cycle: social roles, family life, work
- Sandwich generation
- Financial pressure
- Empty nest
- Taking stock
- Divorce



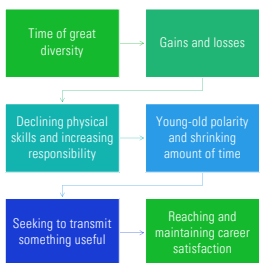
7

AGE IDENTITY VS CHRONOLOGICAL AGE



8

DIVERSITY



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graph TD
    A[Time of great diversity] --> B[Gains and losses]
    B --> C[Declining physical skills and increasing responsibility]
    B --> D[Young-old polarity and shrinking amount of time]
    C --> E[Seeking to transmit something useful]
    D --> F[Reaching and maintaining career satisfaction]
    E --> F
    
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9

PHYSICAL
HEALTH

Primary

- Normative age-related changes that everyone experiences

vs Secondary aging

- Pathological aging- the effects of illness or disease on the body due to environmental exposure or health compromising behaviours

10

SENESCENCE

Age-related changes in appearance

Skin elasticity
Hair colour and loss
Weight gain and loss of muscle

Age-related changes in body functions

Cardiovascular less efficient
Loss of elasticity in lung tissue

Age-related changes in the senses

Vision, hearing, taste, smell (beginning)

11

OBSESSION WITH
YOUTH

12

SUPPORTING OPTIMAL DEVELOPMENT

- Avoid or deal with risk factors
 - Smoking, high alcohol consumption, high levels of stress
- Engage in protective factors
 - Good diet, regular exercise, adequate sleep, good relationships, mental stimulation, flexibility
- Developmental norms
 - People move in and out of states of success and failure (textbook)
- Critical thinking required!

13

COGNITION

14

Schale's stages of cognitive development

Acquisitive	Adolescence
Achieving	Early adulthood
Responsible/ Executive	Middle adulthood
Reintegrative	Late adulthood

Postformal thought

- Subjective
 - Recognise and accept contradiction
 - Capable of achieving synthesis and personal truth
- Pragmatic
 - Look for real world solutions
 - Adaptability in contexts of work and relationships
- Relativistic

15

Responsible/executive stage



Previously acquired knowledge is used to establish oneself in the world



Consider responsibilities to others



Apply postformal thinking to practical problems dealing with relationships on multiple levels



Work to understand and meet the needs of competing groups in large organisations



16

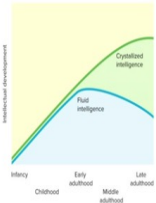


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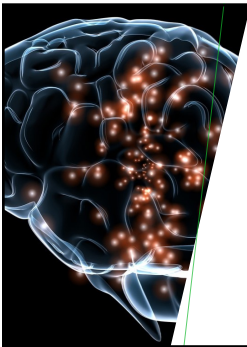
FLUID AND CRYSTALISED INTELLIGENCE

Fluid and Crystallized Intellectual Development Across the Life Span

- Fluid intelligence:
 - Cognitive processing and abilities
 - quickly, attend to multiple stimuli
 - Starts to decrease in middle adulthood
- Crystallised intelligence
 - Ability to store information is more
 - Starts to increase in middle adulthood



18



REDUCING THE RISK OF COGNITIVE DECLINE

- Absence of chronic illness
- Favorable environmental conditions
- Involvement in stimulating activities
- Flexible personality at midlife
- Relationships with high cognitive functioning individuals
- Sense of achievement and mastery
- Exercise

19

WORK



20

Expertise and career challenges

- High level knowledge
- Domain specific, accumulated over time
- Enhanced practical problem-solving abilities
- Middle aged workers
 - Physical strength, agility, perceptual speed ↓
 - Job knowledge, problem-solving, social skills ↑
- Important role as mentors

Challenges:

- Globalization of work.
- Rapid developments in information technologies.
- Downsizing of organizations.
- Pressure to choose early retirement.
- Concerns about pensions and health care.

Career changes in midlife:

- Some are self-motivated.
- Others are the consequence of losing one's job.



21

MOST LIKELY TO BE AUTOMATED

- Loan officer
- Paralegal
- Retail
- Baker
- Construction / labour
- Power plant operator

22

ERIKSON

Generativity vs Stagnation

Generativity – develop a positive legacy

Stagnation – self absorption

23



End of life adulthood:
65 to 90

Life adult transition: Age 60 to 65



Consolidating life structure
for middle adulthood:
35 to 60

Age 50 transition:
50 to 55

Entry life structure for
middle adulthood:
45 to 50

Middle adult transition: Age 40 to 45



Consolidating life structure
for early adulthood:
20 to 30

Age 20 transition:
20 to 25

Entry life structure for
early adulthood:
22 to 28

Early adult transition: Age 17 to 22

*LEVINSON'S
PERIODS/
SEASONS OF
ADULT
DEVELOPMENT*

24

LEVINSON

Middle adulthood

Transition through conflicts / tensions

- Being young vs being old
- Being destructive vs being constructive
- Being masculine vs feminine
- Being attached to others vs being separated from others

Midlife Crisis?

25

Levinson's seasons of adult lives

- Normative crisis model
- Originally, only seasons of men's lives
- Used the biographical method, so small sample
- Later replicated with women
- **Life structure** – the underlying pattern
 - Relationships, work, friendships, leisure
- Sequence characterised by eras and transitions

Each stable life structure is followed by period of transition in which structure is reexamined.

The diagram illustrates the sequence of life stages. For men, the eras are: Early adulthood (20-30), Middle adulthood (30-40), and Late adulthood (40-50). Transitions occur between these eras. For women, the eras are: Early adulthood (20-30), Middle adulthood (30-40), and Late adulthood (40-50). Transitions occur between these eras. The diagram also shows the 'End of life' at age 60-70.

Bee & Boyd, 2011

26

RELATIONSHIPS

- Marriage
- Divorce
- Parenting
- Grandparent's
- Aging parents

27

- Boomerang generation
 - Adult children moving home
 - Cultural expectations
 - Effects on parents' development

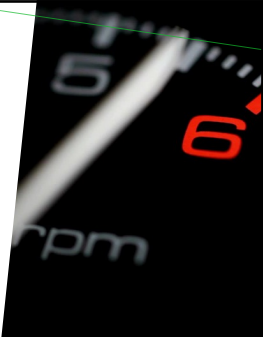
28

SANDWICH GENERATION



29

- Double shift



30

DIVERSITY IN DEVELOPMENT

- Development becomes increasingly diverse
- Environmental factors – Bronfenbrenner
- Diverse cultures and social meaning

31

Middle adulthood is said to be:

- A period of maximum expertise and accomplishment and an internal sense of authority and competence (Stewart & Torges, 2006)
- A vital role in society not able to be filled by younger adults. "Middle-aged people can do more, earn more, and they run the world."
(Dr David Bainbridge, 2012)

What do you think?

32
